

AUDITION CALL

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

by Luigi Pirandello · translated by Edward Storer

A Village Players production

Lausanne, Switzerland

About this audition

The Village Players, Lausanne, are casting Pirandello's metatheatrical comedy *Six Characters in Search of an Author* for a bold minimalist staging. Eight live performers carry the production. The first quarter of an hour is committed comedy. The last quarter of an hour is not.

The play opens on a working theatre company at rehearsal — and is interrupted, in front of the audience, by six characters from an unfinished play, who arrive demanding to be staged. What follows is one long argument about whether the actors can play them, whether the play they carry is real enough to be staged, and what kind of reality a theatre can hold. By turns very funny and very dark.

Our staging strips the stage to one visual element per act: a circle of chairs in Act One; a two-level set (rehearsal stage above, watching floor below) in Act Two; a single short fountain basin alone on stage in Act Three. The English of this version is contemporary, with the Step-Daughter's register pushed harder than polite English of a hundred years ago could carry. Comedy is in the working actors' bickering and in the Manager's increasing exhaustion. The tragedy belongs to the Six.

HOW TO READ WHAT FOLLOWS

For each of the eight casting tracks — four Characters, the Manager, three Players — this packet gives you a role card with the stats (lines and total word count across the production), a single paragraph of playing direction, a short cold-read line, and the audition scenes to prepare. The Boy and the Child, the two youngest of the Six, are not cast — they are objects on the stage (a coat-and-chair, a wrapped bundle) and appear only briefly in three short video projections. They are described at the end of the packet for reference.

The Father

the brain of the family

161 lines · 4,828 words across the production

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

COLD-READ LINE

“Each one of us has within him a whole world of things, and to every one of us our own world.”

Act Three — the philosophical voice

The Mother

silence that finally screams

36 lines · 544 words across the production

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil; beneath it, when she lifts it, a face the colour of wax. Crushed and terrified, as if pressed down by a weight too great to name. Silent for most of Act One — then, in Act Two, her presence becomes a sound, the only true unmediated cry in the play. Stillness is her language. Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that.

COLD-READ LINE

“It's taking place now. It happens all the time.”

Act Two — the only true unmediated cry

The Step-Daughter

speed and shame turned outward

109 lines · 3,028 words across the production

Dashing, almost impudent, beautiful — in elegant mourning, black worn with style. Speed, shame turned outward, revenge wearing the dress of truth. She knows men look at her and uses the knowing; sex is her oldest weapon and her oldest wound, and she does not pretend either. Never apologetic — the performance is propulsion. Vulgar where vulgarity is the truth, arrogant where arrogance is armour. Her tenderness for the Child — for the bundle — must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy reads as the same wound, pointed in the opposite direction. She has a single projected moment in Act Two — the only audible projection in the production — where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child, then violent with the Boy when she finds the revolver in his pocket. Below the screen, her live body stands silent, listening to her own recorded voice. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him.

COLD-READ LINE

“And I came as mistress of the house.”

Act Two — the shop scene

The Son

the one who will not act

37 lines · 778 words across the production

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing. His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. Make it count.

COLD-READ LINE

“I am an 'unrealised' character, dramatically speaking; and I feel ill at ease in their company.”

Act Three — the refuser defines himself

The Manager

the director on a deadline

198 lines · 3,714 words across the production

Whatever an exhausted, competent theatre director at the end of a difficult week looks like — the schedule burning, faintly contemptuous of the playwright he has been forced to stage, faintly proud of his company. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway. He is wrong in tone almost constantly, and right in instinct almost as often. Do not play him as a fool. Give him compassion. He is everyone in the audience who has ever been forced to make sense of someone else's grief on a deadline.

COLD-READ LINE

“I've lost a whole day over these people.”

Act Three — the curtain line

Player 1

the man with all the hats

40 lines · 532 words across the production

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. The Leading Man's vanity is his spine in Act One: the cook's-cap argument with the Manager, the strut, the offence at being asked to wear a chef's hat in a serious play. The Door-keeper is small, apologetic, and lets the wrong six people in. The Machinist is the one who drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two. Every transition between roles must be visible to the audience — the hat-toss, the change of bearing, the lift of the chin. Lean into the Leading Man early. The contrast with everything else will land harder later.

COLD-READ LINE

“Excuse me — must I really wear a cook's cap? I trained at the Conservatoire for this.”

Act One — the Leading Man's vanity

Player 2

the diva and the props

37 lines · 381 words across the production

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. The Leading Lady is offended at being made to play the Step-Daughter, and offended again when the Step-Daughter laughs at her attempt. The Property Man is the working theatre itself — the table, the folding screen, the pegs, the patience the director has personally exhausted. Two opposite registers in the same body: the vanity that costs nothing, and the labour that costs everything. Let the audience see her flip between them in the same scene. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory.

COLD-READ LINE

“A game! For heaven's sake — we are not children. We are serious actors.”

Act Two — the Leading Lady refusing 'the game'

Player 3

the youngest, and Madame Pace

25 lines · 441 words across the production

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, Madame Pace, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. The Juvenile Lead is eager and slightly ridiculous. The Prompter is in his box, sometimes a court stenographer, sometimes complaining about the draught. Then comes the production's most theatrically demanding moment: Madame Pace, an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne, an apparition summoned by the very arrangement of the stage — hats on pegs, a shop window with the sign *robes et manteaux*, a folding screen. Player 3 enters her costume the way an apparition enters a body — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. Play the comedy of her dialect at full strength; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength too. The audience laughs, and is then disgusted with itself for having laughed — that double sensation is the point of her.

COLD-READ LINE

“This is rank madness. Beautiful rank madness — but madness.”

Act One — the Juvenile Lead

SILENT PRESENCES — NOT CAST

The Boy and the Child — the two youngest of the Six — are not played by performers in this production. The Boy is a black coat and a schoolboy's cap on a wooden chair, with a leather satchel at the chair leg. The Child is a small wrapped bundle of white cloth, carried by the Step-Daughter and the Mother. They appear briefly in three short projections and otherwise live in the chair and the bundle.